



The Rewards of Fasting

Text: Matt 6:16-18

Introduction

This private spiritual discipline of fasting has public reward. When we feel ourselves growing spiritual dry, when we don't sense that cutting-edge anointing, or need that fresh encounter with God, fasting is the secret key that unlocks heaven's door and slams shut the gates of hell. The discipline of fasting releases the anointing, favor and blessing of God in the life of a Christian. Your prayer takes on a powerful edge when you fast. When we take the steps to break out of the ordinary and worship Him, as He deserves, we'll begin to see facets of His being that we never knew existed. God will begin to share secrets with us about Himself, His plans and His desires for us. We will be amazed at the things God will show us as we press in to Him.

Matt 9:14-15 - *Then John's disciples came and asked him, "How is it that we and the Pharisees fast, but your disciples do not fast?" Jesus answered, "How can the guests of the bridegroom mourn while he is with them? The time will come when the bridegroom will be taken from them; then they will fast."*

There is clarity while He is manifested, but when He is not, a fast is needed.

I. Why Do We Fast

- A. *Private* fasts are personal
- B. *Called* fasts are for the church to commit to together
- C. 3 Things We Must Ask Ourselves Before We Fast
 - 1. What are the motives behind the fast?
 - 2. What are the specific needs I am fasting for?
 - 3. Am I determined to minister unto the Lord during my fast? (*Acts 13:2*)

II. 7 Types of Fasts in the Bible

- A. The Esther fast – the 3 day fast (*Esther 4:16*)
- B. The Daniel fast – a 21 day fast (*Daniel 10:2-3,10-11,14*)
- C. The self-examination fast – the 1 day fast (*Lev 23:27, Jer 36:3*)
- D. The fast before a battle (*Judges 20:26*)

- E. Fasting to lift God's judgment from another's life (*1 Kings 21:27-29*)
- F. The fast for healing (*Isa 58:6-9*)
- G. The dominion fast – the 40 day fast (*Matt 4*)

III. The Effect of Godly Fasting (*Ezra 8:21*)

- A. God will reveal to you:
 - 1. The right way to fast. He'll help you at the transitions.
 - 2. The effect on your little ones, your children
 - 3. The effect on your substance, resources, or finances

IV. 7 Things To Remember When We Fast

- A. Remember to establish a place and time to pray.
- B. Remember to get God's direction on the type of fast you will do (a full fast or partial as found in Daniel).
- C. Remember, closeness to the Lord is your goal.
 - 1. Don't let the legal aspects of fasting and worldly things drown this goal out.
 - 2. This season of sacrifice will also be a season of warfare, and you will need to be at your best.
- D. Remember to enjoy the many spiritual rewards of fasting.
- E. Remember to have your favorite worship music available and spend time worshipping often.
- F. Remember to have an accountability partner.
- G. Remember, if the fast doesn't mean anything to you, it won't mean anything to God.
- H. Without being combined with prayer and the word, fasting is little more than dieting.
- I. Fasting is a continual prayer before God.
 - 1. At times you will be prompted into deep prayer. Enjoy.
 - 2. At times your energy is sapped and you just can't seem to focus in prayer at all. Don't condemn yourself. God sees your sacrifice.

Final Thought

When we fast, we are seriously seeking God's face. Fasting disrupts business as usual. Is that what we're looking for? Are we crying out to God to do something in us that He has never done before? Are we tired of business as usual? Then it's time to get ready to begin our fast.